

the brand-new thing that they don't understand and are not responsible for. If instead that network had been involved in your project — if they'd been in a position to share the credit — they'd be less incentivized to blame it.

Of course, engineers are (mostly) not scheming viziers who make purely self-interested decisions. When asked who to blame, they usually make a good-faith effort to answer honestly. But in an area where there's no single clear right answer, it's human nature to be at least a little bit guided by your incentives. Nobody likes to think they're responsible for a group failure.

Conclusion

Credit and blame are the currencies of tech companies (and often directly translate to the actual amount of currency you get to take home). For technical roles, managers assign credit and blame based on lots of quiet conversations with their trusted engineers. This can be a rude awakening for very junior engineers who are used to having their work assessed by an expert grader (or less junior engineers who haven't yet shaken that mindset completely).

Don't expect to get credit simply by putting your head down and doing good work. You have to find some way to tell people what you're doing and why it's important: internal blog posts, mentioning it in 1:1s with your manager, or anything else you can think of. But don't take self-promotion too far. It's a bad idea to try and hoard all the credit for your projects, for two reasons.

First, sharing credit with other people gives them a reason to talk positively about your project. Credit is not a zero-sum game: if you do it right, you can get other people to build up your credit for you. Second, hoarding credit sets yourself up as a lightning rod for blame. Projects where the credit is concentrated in one or two people are automatically² blamed for complex problems, because nobody is incentivized to defend them.

1. This is a classic example of an illegible-but-essential part of a software company. I wrote about this general phenomenon in *Seeing like a software company*.

⇐

2. Of course, if you do really screw up, you'll be blamed no matter what. I'm talking here about complex failures where it's non-trivial to attribute blame to a single source.

⇐

FRED TALKS

6th October 2026

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A new Economic Research paper measuring Codex’s economic potential at the frontier.

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Agentic AI changes the unit of knowledge work from single interactions to delegated, long-horizon tasks. Chatbot interactions are often short and self-contained. Agents can operate independently for minutes or hours while orchestrating tool calls, interacting with environments, and iterating towards solutions. As a result, agents are quickly becoming the most powerful AI tool for work.

Over the last year, we witnessed this transformation first-hand at OpenAI. For the first few months after Codex was released to the public, ChatGPT remained the default AI tool for work within OpenAI. Through August 2025, the average OpenAI worker spent less than 10% of their tokens on Codex. Now, every department, including non-technical departments such as Legal and Recruiting, uses Codex as their primary AI tool for work. This pattern reflects what we believe will be the future of work given the expanded capabilities and accessibility of agentic tools.

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vulnerable to other people coming in to claim credit. You can tell they’re jealously guarding whatever credit they’ve managed to accumulate. The lesson this kind of engineer hasn’t learned is that **you can often accumulate credit best by giving it away**.

To see why, consider how credit flows *up* inside a tech company. I wrote above that your manager can’t assess the quality of your technical work on their own, but instead has to rely on other engineers they trust. They’ll quietly ask those engineers “hey, was this project really that impressive?”. In fact, often there are multiple layers of this at play¹. In big companies, line managers usually don’t decide who gets promoted or who gets a raise: they make recommendations to their manager, who has their own network of trusted engineers (confusingly, sometimes these networks overlap). The point is that **there is a large group of people behind the scenes who will quietly and informally judge the value of your work**.

Succeeding at a tech company is largely about finding ways to get these people on your side. The easiest way is to share your credit with them — and since you don’t know who exactly is in this group, you should be sharing your credit freely. When you get feedback from other engineers, publicly thank them and mention them in your internal posts about the project. Find opportunities to ask for small favors, so you have an excuse to give other people credit. As best you can, make your individual projects at least partially *group* projects.

Sharing credit with others gives them a reason to support you. A shared project you’ve worked on reflects well on everybody: on you, for working well with others, on the people you’ve worked with, for the same reason, and for your manager, for fostering such a great environment of cooperation. Lots of people have good reason to talk that project up, because it’s partly their project too. On the other hand, a project you’ve jealously kept to yourself reflects well on nobody: you come across as antisocial and your peers come across as unhelpful.

Blame

Blame operates by the same rules as credit. When something goes badly wrong, managers will ask their networks “hey, who screwed up here?” The answer to this question is never simple. Even on a purely technical level, failures always involve an interaction between multiple complex systems, any one of which could conceivably have been built so as to avoid the failure. In other words, **competent engineers can assign blame pretty much wherever they want**.

Because of this, it’s risky to have a project for which you’re clearly the only one getting credit. When something goes wrong, the network of people who will assign blame will likely be implicated in every part of the system but yours. They will be incentivized to attribute fault to

Many big tech companies encourage this attitude, because it helps them recruit smart graduates. They fashion their workplaces to look and feel like a university, even calling the physical space “campuses”. But it’s still work, not school. If you treat it like school, you are going to have a bad time.

Taking credit

The first lesson many new engineers learn is that **you have to take credit for your work**. If you silently jump in to help a struggling project and get it back on track, there’s no guarantee of reward. Credit will naturally flow to the project lead, not you. In fact, if this project is outside of your direct team, it’s likely you will be *punished* for it: to your manager, it will look like you’re simply doing nothing at all.

Even when your manager is watching your work, credit is largely uncorrelated with how well you did. That’s because, unlike at school, **you are the subject-matter expert on your own work**. Software systems are so complicated that only the people who work on them can hope to understand them, and even that understanding is always imperfect. If even experts can’t reliably estimate the difficulty of changes, how is your manager supposed to assess your technical performance? The answer is they aren’t. They’re simply not qualified to assess it.

Instead, smart managers will find engineers on your team they trust and ask them how you’re doing. On small teams that have worked on a single codebase for a long time, this works okay, because everyone’s familiar enough to judge everyone else’s work. On large teams with a high rate of codebase churn, it goes badly, since they’re just guessing. On teams with a nasty, cutthroat culture, it sometimes goes *very* badly, since this is a good opportunity to actively sabotage the engineers who might threaten you.

Experienced engineers know how to **take the credit themselves**. When they do something good, they tell their manager about it. They write internal posts explaining why it was technically difficult and how they solved it (the audience for these is partially those trusted engineers, and partially the managers who will see a long technical post and think “wow!” without reading it). They actively build trust with their management chain. Worrying about this stuff is the beginning of playing politics.

Giving credit

There’s a kind of engineer who’s learned how to take credit but hasn’t learned any other lessons yet. They’re proactive about telling people what they’ve done, and they always maintain a “brag doc”. In particular, they love to talk about the parts they did *by themselves*, since those are least

Codex adoption grew in tandem with Codex’s capabilities. As Codex leveraged stronger models and new product features, it became capable of taking on an expanding set of productive tasks. Across Individual users, Organizational users, and OpenAI workers, we document four trends over the past year:

- **People use Codex for longer-horizon work.** By May 2026, 80.6% of sampled individual users made at least one Codex request estimated to exceed 30 minutes of human work, 70.2% made one estimated to exceed one hour, and 25.6% made at least one Codex request estimated to exceed eight hours.
- **Codex became the primary AI tool for every department at OpenAI.** Engineering moved first, but Legal, Finance, and Recruiting crossed into Codex being their primary AI tool around April 2026. For the average OpenAI worker, Codex usage now accounts for more than 85% of output tokens. Since Codex users tend to use more tokens than non-users, its share of overall tokens is even higher: Codex accounts for 99.8% of weekly output tokens generated within OpenAI.
- **Non-developer adoption grew especially rapidly, outpacing developer adoption.** Since August 2025, non-developer users rose 137x for individual users, 189x for organizational users, and 12x within OpenAI.
- **Codex enabled OpenAI workers to do tasks outside their job description.** While technical usage is still most prevalent among engineers, non-technical users regularly use Codex to take on coding or technical execution, including automation, data transformation, tooling, debugging, and structured analysis.

Agents work longer hours on harder tasks

Nearly a quarter of all Codex requests are for tasks that would take a person more than one hour to complete⁽¹⁾. As Codex’s capacity for independent long-context work improved, users shifted from short interactions toward more difficult tasks with longer horizons.

The chart below estimates the share of individual users that crossed four human-time thresholds: tasks that would take a person more than 30 minutes, more than one hour, more than four hours, and more than eight hours⁽²⁾. From December 2025 to May 2026, the share of users who made a request that was estimated to correspond to work that would take a person more than 30 minutes rose to 80.6%. The share making a request that would take a person more than one hour rose to 70.2%. The share requesting work that would take a person more than eight hours grew the fastest from a low base.

The growth in agentic usage can be seen in daily Codex runtime. Among daily active users at OpenAI, the heaviest users ask Codex to run many hours of agent work in a single day. By June 2026, users at the 99th percentile regularly generated more than 60 hours of Codex agent turns per day, distributed across multiple, parallel agents. As Codex became more powerful and parallelizable, users moved from only asking Codex for one answer at a time into increasingly orchestrating multiple agent tasks over the course of a day.

Adoption continues to move from engineers to the rest of OpenAI

Engineers at OpenAI began adopting Codex first, gradually. The average engineer at the company shifted the majority of their usage of OpenAI products to Codex by December 2025. Today, the average engineer generates 99% of their output tokens with Codex rather than ChatGPT. Legal, finance, and recruiting crossed over to majority use of Codex later, around April 2026, but their transitions were much faster. The average lawyer or recruiter at OpenAI now generates more than 85% of their output tokens on Codex.

Over the last six months, Codex usage has deepened and intensified at OpenAI. Among active internal users, change in combined output tokens rose sharply across departments. Research saw the biggest jump: by June 2026, median use was 56 times higher than in November 2025. Customer Support rose 32 times and Engineering rose 27 times, while Legal grew more gradually but still reached 13 times its November level.

These two patterns together illustrate how Codex has transformed how OpenAI uses AI to do productive work. Across the company, users are switching from chatbots to agents as their primary form of AI interaction and are deploying an exponentially growing amount of agentic labor.

Non-developers are the fastest-growing user groups

Across all user groups—OpenAI, organizational, and individual users—Codex use began with developers, the natural target audience for what began as a coding tool. However, as Codex expanded toward more general knowledge work, adoption among non-developers grew even more quickly. As shown in the user growth chart below, weekly non-developer users rose faster than developer users among individual, organizational, and OpenAI populations. By early June 2026, non-developer individual users multiplied 137 times since August 2025. Non-developer organizational users increased 189-fold, and non-developer OpenAI users increased 12-fold, likely because this group already started at a well above average starting point.

Obsessing over the self never provides peace. It cannot make you whole, as you aren't the whole. Becoming whole starts by putting down the rock you didn't even know you were carrying.

Because at the end of the day—and at the end of a Montana night—the point was never yourself.

It was never the pyramid.

It was never the optimization.

It was the people around the fire.

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Giving and taking credit in big tech companies

SEANGOEDECKE.COM RSS FEED · 02 AUG 2026 · [SOURCE](#)

Engineers often complain that visibility should be their manager's job. In other words, they think engineers should be able to focus on the code, while their manager figures out who's doing well and rewards them.

This attitude is an extension of the “school fantasy”: the idea that your workplace should operate by the same rules as your school or university. After all, you didn't have to worry about “visibility” during your education. You simply did the assignments and tests you were given, and if you did well you were rewarded with a good grade.

But the bread and dressing layers exist to serve the middle. That’s the payload. Everything is in service of the payload. And the payload circulates benefits back to the edges, and then the cycle repeats. Even if you think this is oversimplified claptrap, temporarily assuming it’s true will help you.

What if nearly everything you focused on — calendar, habits, goals — aimed to improve your relational life somehow? What if you took this as a challenge for even a week? Your lens on the world changes dramatically.

You say yes differently.
You say no more clearly.
Your to-do list for life slowly transforms.

What if all that you focused on, all that you do, had to improve that middle layer in some fashion?

It’s a damn hard question if you’ve been on the *self*-help train for a while. I get it.

So let’s try something easier: **What if it only changed how you approach your to-do list? Try hamburger-first each day for 1-2 weeks and tell me what happens. Add and do the things that improve your relational life FIRST. Nothing on the list? Create something. It could be as simple as cooking dinner for your spouse, complimenting at least three people a day for a week, or introducing yourself to the barista you see every morning. Getting started is how you get grooving.**

ARE YOU DOING SELF-HELP, OR IS SELF-HELP DOING YOU?

For friendship makes prosperity more shining and lessens adversity by dividing and sharing it.
— Marcus Tullius Cicero

In his *Moral Letters to Lucilius*, Seneca the Younger famously wrote that “These individuals [who put money at the center of life] have riches just as we say that we ‘have a fever,’ when really the fever has us.”

What if self-help is similar?

The shift does not mean every non-developer is using Codex in the same way as an engineer. Rather, it means that more non-developers are using Codex for some kind of agentic work.

Codex is expanding the horizon of potential productive work

Codex enables non-technical departments to accelerate workflows previously bottlenecked by technical expertise. The heat map below compares inferred occupations within OpenAI to the type of work represented in Codex outputs. Engineering and coding show up as the largest category for data science and research, whereas knowledge work is the largest category for finance and business operations, marketing, operations, and other departments.

That said, agentic tools can expand what an individual worker can do. For instance, over one-fourth of work done with Codex by workers in business functions was engineering or coding. Agents can lower the cost of moving across task boundaries and help workers do adjacent work that used to require more specialized technical support.

Occupation vs. work done with Codex

Consolidated inferred department	Work category				
	Engineering / Coding	Data Analysis	Financial Analysis	Knowledge Work	Other
Engineering	72%	4%	1%	18%	5%
Data Science / Research	51%	10%	0%	30%	9%
Finance / Biz Ops	31%	9%	16%	34%	10%
Product / Marketing / Ops	25%	3%	7%	51%	15%
Other	50%	7%	2%	38%	4%

Share of output tokens within department

What this means for agents’ economic potential

Increased use of agentic tools by non-engineer employees expands the frontier of what these workers can do. That matters for businesses deciding how to redesign workflows, for employees learning which skills become more valuable, and for policymakers and researchers trying to understand how AI changes the labor market.

Our paper shows how frontier users adopt capable agentic tools at the frontier. Our results demonstrate what unfolds when people have broad, low-friction access to capable agentic tools: as the tools improve, people use them for longer, more complex, and more cross-functional work. As time goes on, this is likely to be what the future of work looks like.

- [2026](#)
- [Economic Research](#)
- [Codex](#)

Author

OpenAI

Footnotes

1. Task horizon is estimated using an LLM-as-judge with access to Codex transcripts.

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2. These thresholds are model-estimated, so they should be treated as directional rather than exact. This is also based only on individual data and based on the queries of a random sample of 0.1% of users.

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MASLOW’S HAMBURGER OF NEEDS?

“The more one forgets himself—by giving himself to a cause to serve or another person to love—the more human he is and the more he actualizes himself. What is called ‘self-actualization’ is not an attainable aim at all, for the simple reason that the more one would strive for it, the more he would miss it. In other words, self-actualization is possible only as a side-effect of self-transcendence.”

— Viktor E. Frankl

How can we easily keep ourselves on the right track?

As I remind myself these days: **It’s the relationships, stupid.**

For a nice simple visual, let’s revise Maslow’s pyramid with all of this in mind. This is easy, as Maslow never drew his model as a rigid pyramid!

He described “classes” of needs that were unfixed, overlapping, and that could reverse in order. And believe it or not, self-actualization was only ever for the “self-actualizing minority.” In the 1960s, his work was co-opted by consultants and corporate trainers who needed a progression to sell. [True story.](#)

Given all this, and after decades of trial and error, here’s where I’ve landed:

Maslow’s Hamburger of Needs.

Ahhh… what? Not to worry. It’s the same good ol’ Maslow ingredients, but I think of it as a hamburger:

For our purposes, the meat, the whole point of the hamburger, is that middle layer: relationships. That is the center of life. The heartbeat.

As luck would have it, when you improve the heartbeat, it also feeds everything else.

You’ll notice that the meat contains Abe’s most-important addendum—the sixth level of self-transcendence. Focusing on things bigger than yourself is a critical piece of the ultimate puzzle. Faith, nature, family, meditation, causes that outlive you, etc. – take your pick. But be careful. If you do it to inflate the ego or impress others, it’s self-obsession again, not self-transcendence. If you need credit, it doesn’t count.

Of course, it should go without saying but the top and bottom layers matter a lot. A hamburger is a giant mess without the bun. Friends will get sick of you crashing on their couch and eating their food.

We've established this. But there is a follow-on assumption that matters a lot.

If I fix the things that aren't OK, all will be well. If I improve myself enough, if I only work hard enough, I can finally eliminate my suffering.

I hate to inform you, but this doesn't work. I'm also thrilled to inform you that this doesn't work. You can stop picking up a lot of boulders.

There is one book that most opened my eyes to this reframe – *Already Free: Buddhism Meets Psychotherapy on the Path of Liberation* by Bruce Tift. It offers a terrifying but ultimately liberating realization: there is no perfect escape from suffering. It doesn't exist. But there is a way to find your long-sought unclenching, and it lies in cultivating your skill of acceptance as much as that of improvement.

Now, I can hear the chorus: *Has Tim gone soft? Given up the good fight? Is he telling everyone to chill after he himself red-lined and got the spoils? How convenient! And...*

Hold on a second. I'm telling you – intelligent acceptance is high-leverage. It's probably one of the highest forms of leverage. This is an approach that helps preserve your energy for where it really matters. My early forays into Stoicism and Seneca The Younger helped set the conditions for my biggest wins from 2004-2010. Still, I only learned a small fraction of what I needed.

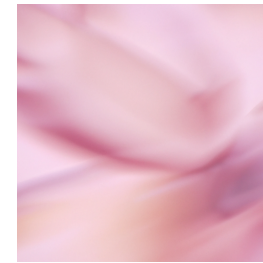
So how do you cultivate your skill of acceptance without becoming complacent?

This is a big question and what I love about Bruce's book. Compared to a strictly Western or purely Eastern book, he blends them and offers a surgical guide to using *both* action and acceptance. You don't have to be a bull in a china shop or a cow in the rain; there is a middle path. That middle path is where all the gold is buried.

If the only tool you have is "self-improvement," you'll become a hammer looking for nails in a world that is 50% screws. I tried it. It can create the veneer of success, but it will leave your inner world in turmoil.

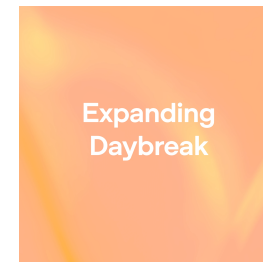
Suffice to say, the dual dance is the most joyful. Upgrade your toolkit with that in mind. Read Bruce's book. If it doesn't click, try *Radical Acceptance: Embracing Your Life with the Heart of a Buddha* by Tara Brach, which had a large impact on my life a decade before I found Bruce's book. In a sense, the writing of Seneca prepared me for Tara, which then prepared me for Bruce. So grab them all and thank me later.

If you want serenity, you need to be able to put the Serenity Prayer into practice. Seriously, I read it all the time.



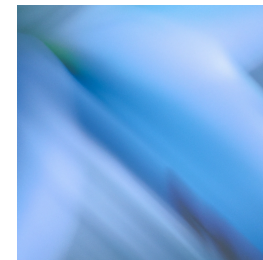
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The Self-Help Trap: What 20+ Years of “Optimizing” Has Taught Me

TIM FERRISS · 08 MAR 2026 · [SOURCE](#)

One danger of modern self-help.

“We cannot reason ourselves out of our basic irrationality. All we can do is to learn the art of being irrational in a reasonable way.”

— Aldous Huxley, *Island*

It was cold out, but none of us were cold.

I sat with five men in the mountains of Montana. As the sun set, the fire in the center cast dancing light on our faces. Reclined against fallen trees in a tight circle, we ate mushrooms and fish we’d found under trees and along streams. The whole crew burst into laughter yet again, and one of the guides passed around a fresh batch of pine needle tea.

Bathed in warmth, I took off a layer and glanced skyward through an opening in the trees. The stars shone like crystals on black velvet, and the show—the biggest meteor shower of the year—was starting.

In that moment, there was nothing to do. Nothing to improve. Nothing to fix.

It was perfect.

The older I get, the more I think that self-help can be a trap. Sometimes the cure is worse than the disease. I say this after ~20 years of writing self-help and a lifetime of consuming it.

Spend enough time in the world of “improvement,” and you’ll notice something strange: The people most obsessed with self-help are often the least helped by it. Behind the smiles and motivational quotes, behind closed doors and after a drink or two, the truth is that they’re not able to outsmart their worries.

On one hand, perhaps this unhappiness is precisely what lands one in self-development in the first place, right? I long assumed this about myself, and it’s partially true.

Below are a few questions that I’ve found helpful for nudging this particular tectonic plate in the right direction:

- If you couldn’t tell a soul about “the work” you’re doing, would you still do it? If not, you’re not developing yourself; you’re curating yourself.
- How has sharing your personal development created tradeoffs?
- If you *had to* take down 20% of your most popular posts, which would you take down and why?
- Are you describing strong catalysts (psychedelics, The Hoffman Process, you name it) instead of doing the post-session integration that makes them truly valuable?
- Have you become more robust or more fragile by offering your inner workings up to public vote?
- Has your social presence made you more or less of the person you want to be? How would the you of three or five years ago feel about your last year of posts? What about the you of 10 years from now?

3. Assumption

What are the fundamental assumptions behind your doing “the work”?

Let’s begin with [a Buddhist parable](#) that I first heard from the incredible [Jack Kornfield](#).

The old Master points to a big boulder and asks a disciple, “See that large rock over there?”

“Yes”, says the disciple.

“Do you think it’s heavy?” continues the Master.

“Yes, it’s very heavy!” replies the student.

“Only if you pick it up,” smiles the Master.

Once again, the fundamental assumption behind self-help is often this: Something is not OK. Something is wrong. Something is not enough. Something needs fixing. If I can’t find it, I’ll create it.

Digging further, focusing on improving the self is often in service of trying to control the world, especially if things were unpredictable or unstable when growing up. Banish emotion, live by spreadsheets, and all can be well. All can be *controlled*, or so the illusion goes. But as soon as you're interacting with – let alone depending on – other people, control as a construct goes out the window. And so we consciously or subconsciously avoid the messiness. This is also one of the reasons why a lot of optimizing achiever folks have a hard time in intimate relationships.

So how do I think about “self-help” now, having realized all of the above?

It is refreshingly simple: the goal is to build and improve my relationships. The sooner you get on the real field with real players, the sooner you can get to playing soccer and engaging with life. No more auto-fellating, even with the best of intentions. We've evolved over millions of years to be deeply social creatures, and the more you dodge that IN REAL PHYSICAL LIFE, the more you will suffer. This is why solitary confinement in prisons is often considered cruel and unusual punishment... and yet we do it to ourselves all the time.

There are a few questions that help corral this tectonic plate of *intention*:

- How does any given “self-help” help me in my relationships, and how can I apply it with other people *today* or *this week*?
- How can I take the ship out of the harbor and test it where it counts?

2. Audience

Do you have an audience for your self-development? If so, be careful.

Nary a minute can be spent on social media without bumping into a CAPS-rich “HOW X CHANGED MY LIFE” or a photo carousel of an ayahuasca retreat. If only Costa Rica got a dime for every bikini-clad healer under a waterfall!

Welcome to the theater of performative self-help. I won't belabor this, as we've all seen it, but I suggest reading about the [insidious creep of audience capture here](#), and don't forge ahead in the fame game before reading [11 reasons not to become famous](#). It's hard to put the genie back in the bottle, so you should know what that genie will do to your life.

But the truth is that most of us aren't extreme examples of this. But even minor tendencies in this direction can do extreme damage over time.

On the other hand, what if self-help *itself* is actually creating or amplifying unhappiness?

Modern self-help contains an in-built flaw:

To continually improve yourself, you must continually locate the ways you are broken.

Fortunately, there are a few perspective shifts that make all the difference. It took me embarrassingly long to figure them out.

To get started, let's take a fresh look at an old concept.

MASLOW'S HIERARCHY OF NEEDS?

“I suppose it is tempting, if the only tool you have is a hammer, to treat everything as if it were a nail.”

— Abraham Maslow

Maslow's Hierarchy of Needs has captured the minds of hundreds of millions. It offers simplicity in a terrifyingly complex world.

Abraham Maslow's “[A Theory of Human Motivation](#)” (1943) contains five levels, which are typically presented like the below pyramid. This one is pulled from [the Wikipedia entry](#) on the subject:

We've all seen it. Clear as day, you can see the goal post at the top: self-actualization.

LFG! It's time to journal and 80/20 myself! Pass me a shaman and some modafinil.

That's the mission. That's the point.

Right?

But hold on. A critical footnote got lost in the shuffle. In his later writings, especially notes compiled in *[The Farther Reaches of Human Nature](#)* (1971), Maslow added a *sixth* level above self-actualization:

Self-transcendence.

That update never quite made it out of the crib. The consultants are to blame, but that comes later.

Self-transcendence means going beyond the self — seeking connection with something greater, such as service to others, nature, art, or the divine. Why is it important? Well, for one thing, as [Tony Robbins](#) put it at an event long ago: “‘I, I, I, me, me, me’ gets to be a really fucking boring song.”

But it’s not just a boring song; it’s dangerous to your health.

DON’T BE A SOMO

“**The man who renounces himself, comes to himself.**”

— Ralph Waldo Emerson

Self-help is dangerous precisely because it easily becomes self-fixation.

A focus on improving the self usually first requires finding problems with the self. This is quite the pickle. In a society that rewards problem-solving, you can end up hallucinating or exaggerating unease in order to fix it. This leaves you always in the red, always one step behind. Imagine a dog chasing its tail that has committed to being unhappy until it catches the tail... but it’s always just a few inches short. Still, it whirls around and around, “doing the work.” Perfection always recedes by one more book, one more seminar, one more habit tracker.

Put in more colorful terms, misdirected self-help turns you into a self-obsessed masturbatory [ouroboros](#) (SOMO).

To remind me of the SOMO risk, I have this sticker on my laptop:

A picture is worth a thousand social media posts about yourself. Sticker from [Porous Walker](#).

Now, to be clear, I still love self-help. Ain’t no way Timmy can give up the sauce. There’s a place for it.

From The Bible to Seneca, and from Ben Franklin to Stephen Covey and far beyond, there’s a lot of valuable advice worth taking. I used to mainline it all – no time to waste! – and jump straight into action. This did some good, but there was a lot of collateral damage.

Why?

Because there are at least three “tectonic plates of self-help” that I couldn’t see for decades, and they dictate how much net-positive or net-negative comes from all the striving. Before you sprint, you want to calibrate your direction.

THE THREE TECTONIC PLATES OF SELF-HELP

“As to methods there may be a million and then some, but principles are few. The man who grasps principles can successfully select his own methods. The man who tries methods, ignoring principles, is sure to have trouble.”

— Harrington Emerson

In the last few years, my life has become much more of a joy than a grind, and that’s because I’ve focused on three tectonic plates.

Let’s take a close look at each.

1. Intention

Individual or Social?

Americans, in particular, worship at the altar of the rugged individualist. There are clear upsides to this. But steeped in a culture – offline and especially online – that puts the self on a pedestal, we can take self-improvement to be an end unto itself: a better self.

But is it an end unto itself? Does it automatically produce good things? I now have my doubts.

Here’s one analogy I’ve drawn for myself.

Let’s pretend that life is the game of soccer. You can work on the mechanics of soccer by yourself. You can always get better at dribbling, shooting, and running drills as a solo practitioner. You can read dozens of books, study tape, and earn a PhD in the physics of ball flight. You can post videos of stunning shots on YouTube and get showered by emojis.

But none of this is actually playing the game of soccer.

You can spend your whole life preparing for, instead of playing, the game of life.

But why would anyone, including yours truly, succumb to this?

Subconsciously, it spares you from the messiest but most rewarding game of all: human interaction. Perhaps people hurt or traumatized you long ago. You might also justify the endless polishing, as I did, with some version of “Once I’ve perfected myself, then I’ll be ready for relationships.” But here’s the rub: that practice is exactly endless. You can always get better at dribbling and penalty kicks.